rection. Seen thus, the import of these 20 seats suddenly rises—especially in what could be a tight national election where every seat is worth as many Roman denarii as was paid for sacks of Kerala pepper in ancient days.

For Team Modi, add an ideological zing to that urgency: they are yet to take their debut Lok Sabha seat in Kerala. And they are as close as ever with three this time: Thiruvananthapuram, Thrissur and Pathanamthitta. In fact, the first one, a prestige seat where star Congressman Shashi Tharoor is locked in a grim face-off with Union minister Rajeev Chandrasekhar, has turned into a sizzler because the CPI seems to have settled on man-to-man stalking. Here, it has fielded another tough old bolshie in Pannyan Raveendran against its I.N.D.I.A. ally. A year shy of 80 and a child of India's first Age of Anger, the ex-MP's defiant flowing locks symbolise the Emergency—he has refused to submit to the shears ever since cops then started picking up young rebels with overflowing tropical canopies.

But the triangle hides many axes that frame the contest in unpredictable ways. Rahul's mass entry in Wayanad on April 3 put some complications on display. In 2019, a Rahul roadshow here had invited barbs from the BJP as the crowds waved the green flag of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), an old Congress partner in the local United Democratic Front (UDF). Saffron trolls pounced on its resemblance to the "Pakistan flag" and viralised images—a handy gambit also to suggest that Rahul had sought refuge in a Muslim-flavoured seat (with a 28.7 per cent community share in the district population, against a state average of 26.6 per cent). So this time the UDF partners thought it wise to foreclose the risk. During their 2-km roadshow, Rahul and sister Priyanka went without the Congress tricolour—the swarming

THE GAMEPLAN

LDF

- Focus on anti-CAA protests and steps taken against legislation by LDF to win over the Muslims
- Target BJP for Manipur violence to win over the Christians
- Highlight anti-Kerala attitude of Modi government
- Democracy/ Constitution under threat if Modi elected again

UDF

- Vote for Congress to save India from Modi
- Vote against corrupt Pinarayi government
- Modi and Pinarayi are the same–undemocratic
- Vote for Rahul Gandhi again, repeat 2019 tally
- Support Congress with 'a vote and note' donation

NDA

- Elect BJP to execute Modi guarantees
- Save Kerala from 'Islamic terrorism'
- Both Congress and CPI(M) are playing vote bank politics
- Expose corruption in Pinarayi government and ED cases against CM's daughter Veena
- Aggressively woo Christians in Kerala



IUML infantry did likewise, even if some of them in a show of anger.

But the controversy returned anyway, in inverted form. This time, the jibes flew from Pinarayi! Taunting the UDF duo for "fearing" the BJP, his rhetorical framing slyly referenced the "Pakistan" angle too. While the IUML is a communitarian party of fairly centrist persuasion, and thoroughly mainstream, its mention tends to be made in whisperingly fraught ways. If that didn't suffice to fully bring the Islamist genie out of the bottle, no one needed to complain: the SDPI was at hand. The political wing of the Popular Front of India (PFI), whose fame as a radical Muslim outfit is national by now, declared unconditional support to the Congress. A day later, acting PCC chief M.M. Hassan rejected the offer, but the damage was done. Even the Left upped the sarcasm.

The BJP's foray in Pathanamthitta brought another inversion. Here, in the sacred proximity of Sabarimala temple—which had become a lightning rod for Hindutva polarisation after the Supreme Court verdict on women's entry in 2018—saffron strategists have fielded a Christian: